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Lisa Parrott

Lisa Parrott has established herself as a respected saxophonist, composer, and band leader in both Sydney, Australia and New York City. She has been recognized as a baritone saxophonist in DownBeat polls, was a member of the DIVA Jazz Orchestra, and she continues to compose and perform cutting edge jazz.

Lisa was interviewed via Zoom on June 22, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I am very pleased to have Lisa Parrott with me I'll say this evening. She's morning. And it occurred to me that time-wise I would just about be walking onstage for a gig and you'd just about be waking up the next morning after a gig.

LP: That's exactly right. That's exactly right.

MR: For the people who view this I'll mention that you are New York based but perhaps you can tell us about your current situation or predicament.

LP: Yes. Sorry, I'm just muting things here. Sorry.

MR: As I will.

LP: Okay so yes I live and I'm based in Brooklyn, New York and have been for, since, well I've been in New York since the mid-90s. But at the moment I'm actually in a mandatory hotel quarantine in Sydney, Australia, so I can hang out with Mom and Dad. And they've had that in place in Australia, the Covid 19 restrictions, everybody who comes in, and only returning Australians — because I have a, I'm a dual citizen I'm allowed to come in but I'm also able to leave. If you're a resident of another country you're not allowed in or, and Australians aren't allowed out. That's how intense it is. I feel very grateful that I'm actually, that I'm doing this. You know I've had to take a million different Covid tests to even get to this point and I've been vaccinated but that doesn't even mean anything. But anyway, I'm in Sydney and I'm halfway through quarantine.

MR: Will you be able to hook up with any of the musicians that you played with during your formative years?

LP: I was just texting, I'm having a rehearsal, like literally I'm going from here to a rehearsal, which I'm very excited about. The stars have aligned in that they're both available that day so I'm going to go from here to rehearsing with two friends that I've been playing with since 1988, which is — yeah, so we have a gig a week Friday in Sydney, then we have a gig in my hometown of Newton Castle, which is where Mom and Dad are, and

MR: Speaking —

LP: Back in July, yes, sorry.

MR: Speaking of Mom and Dad I wondered how they felt or how they feel, about both their daughters — your sister Nicki — going across, way across the pond to pursue a life as musicians.

LP: Exactly. I'm the older sister so it's my fault obviously. And both Nicki and I came sort of a year apart. We both got grants from the Australian government to do some private study here. So we actually came separately. And oh my gosh, it's been a massive adjustment I have to say, for Mom and Dad. It's hard. But we both visit regularly and Mom and Dad — Mom's been about half a dozen times; Dad I think has made about more than a dozen trips to New York. Yeah. Mom hates the long travel so Mom's like you have to come and visit, you have to come here. So you know they're 79 and 81 now so I don't want them doing all the travel. Yeah.

MR: Were they musical?

LP: No but music is on always in the house. Music lovers. Mom learned piano as a kid but me and Nicki both went to a musical primary school, elementary school, and we started learning music in school but also started private lessons on piano, and Nick learned flute and I learned clarinet. All classical. So still when you go to Mom and Dad's place the classical music station and jazz radio stations are on like all the time. So there's music always on in the house. So music lovers, yes.

MR: Well we thank them for that.

LP: Yes.

MR: And is that where you heard Sidney Bechet?

LP: Aha. No. That's actually a neighbor who still lives across the street from Mom and Dad. His name is Harry Cantle. He's a trad jazz bass player, I'm not sure, I don't think he plays anymore. I was babysitting his kids and he gave me a Sidney Bechet cassette tape. I think I was about 14 or 15. I think I was 15. And I just fell in love with jazz. That was my first real listen to jazz, I just fell in love with it. And that's what started it all actually. Have you heard the story about the three stringed bass?

MR: I have not, but can I ask first if you recall when you first heard Sidney Bechet was he playing the clarinet or the soprano?

LP: It was both. But what's in my head is soprano saxophone actually. Even though I was playing clarinet I started dabbling a little beyond. No it was actually after Sidney Bechet that I started playing a little bit of saxophone at school and — I can't remember what age — I was a tenor and a soprano player first. I'm trying to remember, I probably was, when I got my first saxophone I was probably 16 or 17, 16 I would say, yeah.

LP: The three stringed bass, so Harry, the bass player who gave me that Sidney Bechet tape, he played bass and because I was like okay, this is it — we already had a little busking group together and, "Nicki, we need, you can't play flute in my group. You have to play tuba or bass if you want to be in my jazz group." I was forming a jazz group. And there was a double bass that had no bridge or any strings or anything, in the school closet at the high school, in the closet at the high school. We brought it home, Harry put three strings on it and a bridge, and I think according to Nicki like he shaved too much off the bridge and the strings were hitting the fingerboard. But he said, his theory was you can't hear the E string anyway so there was no point having an E string. So he always played the three stringed bass. So for the first couple of months Nicki was playing an E stringed bass, I mean a three stringed bass, until we went to a music camp where someone put an E string on the bass for her.

MR: I love those little anecdotes.

LP: Yeah. "You can't hear the E string anyway."

MR: Yeah. There are so many things that happen to young musicians along the way up and I think busking and, you know I was reading your bios and things on your website and it sounds like you were in and out of a number of bands, and there's a lot of education that goes on in that.

LP: Yeah. I met some musicians — I was 17 at the jazz camp. I went to a classical camp, found out about a jazz camp, so the next school holiday I went to that jazz camp. And that's where the first proper like modern jazz group that me and Andrew Dickenson who is a drummer who teaches at Sydney Conservatorium. All of us are still playing. It was Adrian Mears on trombone, who is based in Europe; Nicki on bass; and John Foreman on piano, who actually in the "Idol" of Australia he's done things like "Australian Idol" and all sorts of stuff. He was on TV and stuff like that. So we formed in New Castle, Australia, which is a hundred miles north of Sydney, we formed our first band and that group was together for a couple of years. And at the same time, after high school it'd be like a year and a bit of classical music course before we all moved to Sydney and I started doing the jazz course at the Sydney Conservatorium.

MR: Do you recall what you got paid the first time you did a paying gig?

LP: Well it wasn't jazz, it was a little busking group, I'm pretty sure it was ten bucks each for a Coal Point School event. I do remember the group Blues by Five we had a couple of regular gigs. So I was the oldest at 17. And that was 40 bucks a gig. Not bad. And that was at the Grand Hotel bizarrely enough, on July 6th, I'm playing in the exact same, I'm playing at the Grand Hotel. Oh that was Rumours Tavern. But anyway, we had also a regular gig at the Grand Hotel and fast forward however many years that is, I'm playing

MR: I assume you're going to let the audience know that.

LP: Yes.

MR: In those kind of gigs, this would have been around what year?

LP: From about, that band was formed in '85 so, '85 to '88.

MR: So in your choice of tunes was there a balance between what you all wanted to play and what you felt maybe what we need to play?

LP: The drummer, Andrew, had a massive vinyl collection. Now records in Australia were really expensive. A second-hand record was $15. So I never had a big vinyl collection so I had cassette tapes of people's stuff. But he did. It seemed like always the rhythm section people could afford the albums and all the horn players, we were like listening to the rhythm section's albums — Monk, Miles, just all classic modern jazz stuff. So we did a ton of like Miles sort of stuff. So it was a mix of like a lot of standards, modern jazz tunes, bebop, I was playing tenor and soprano although I had an alto which is the exact same alto that's still in that room, it's still my main horn. Yeah. And right before I moved to Sydney, before we all moved to Sydney, I'd gotten a Mark VI that — I'd come into a Mark VI in my hometown. And it got squashed by a speaker at a gig. And I became an alto player after that.

MR: I love that because you could form a question like, "Was it the higher pitch that just spoke to you that you wanted to go to the E flat horn?" No. My horn got squished.

LP: Well to be honest I still think my most natural horn is the soprano saxophone, which is the horn I probably play the least but I love playing it. And there are a couple of groups that I'm playing in where I'll play baritone and soprano saxophone, just like say John Surman, like that sort of, you know, he sounds amazing on both of those instruments. Yeah, I still think, and it's probably because I grew up playing clarinet, it's the same reason, the clarinet. That's my theory.

MR: Yeah. It's a little easier to get on the plane, too.

LP: Yeah. Well that's true.

MR: So there was a point, obviously you went to the conservatory and you had decided that my career is in music at that point?

LP: Yeah. Oh I decided that at about 15 when Nicki and I were in a local marching band. And I decided this is what I'm good at, this is what I want to keep doing. Yeah. It was called the Marching Koalas, it was 120 kids, the first American-style marching band in Australia, and they're still going. Me and Nicki were in the original group. We marched at Disneyland in the Tournament of Roses Parade in '83.

MR: Now that's some traveling for a gig.

LP: Yes. Yeah we spent two weeks in L.A. That was definitely like okay, I want to keep

MR: I spoke recently with Adrian Cunningham. And his opinion was that Australia has — I'm trying to remember his exact words but basically he said Australia does not have any indigenous music of its own. How do you feel about that statement?

LP: Well aboriginal people have been playing music for 50,000 years in Australia.

MR: He did mention that, I should have said that, I think that was his exception to what he was thinking. He was talking more about I believe like the pop music and jazz has been fashioned after music from somewhere else.

LP: Yes, yes. I'm a lot older than Adrian, and I was fortunate enough to in the early 80s, I think it was '83 is when there started to be a jazz course formed at Sydney Conservatorium. So I was there only five years into that program. And Nicki was in the same year also, the bass player I'm going to be playing with on Friday, and his name is Don Burrows. He only recently just passed away, an incredible clarinet, bari, he got me on bari. I owe him everything actually. I owe my career to Don Burrows. He, so this was the year after my tenor got squashed. I was just a soprano player for a year. And he got me playing baritone sax in the big band. He was like, "I think you'd be great on it, you know, I think you have an ear for that, you know. Nicki's a bass player, you hear that, I think you'd be great on that." I was like, "I don't want to carry something like that around." But he was like, "Just trust me on that, I want to put you in the big band on bari." Now he is someone who traveled, he was well known over here as well, he traveled all over Europe, he traveled to India and was very, and Brazil, and he took music from all sorts of parts of the world including the States, and formed this jazz course. And at the time the curriculum was very much based around learning standards as a way of learning improvisation. But he was also incredibly encouraging to compose your own music. So those sort of guys, yes I feel like there is an actual thing, there is an Australian quality about Australian jazz. And I feel like I'm a product of that because we're not as influenced by American jazz so I feel like there's a lot of Australian jazz musicians who are very unique. Because it's so isolated. I feel like I came up with my own way of doing things because I was doing gigs from such a young age, before I even went to the Conservatorium. I was already playing gigs because I'd studied classical music and everything and had very good ears and so I was already improvising. So I'd already came up with my own concept of how to do things. And my favorite Australian musicians are like that. And I think isolation breeds that. And case in point, someone like Don Burrows but even more so my hero on the saxophone is Bernie McGann — Bernie McGann – M-C-G-A-N-N. Alto player who just, who just was a total original. I think he was on the scene starting in the late 50s, certainly early 60s. I don't even know how to describe him. You'd have to — there's not a lot of recordings because unfortunately the Australian jazz

at all either. It was sort of out of our reach financially and just was not available to us. But Bernie McGann, he sounds a bit like Sonny Rollins on alto, some people say he sounds a little bit of Ornette's sound, that he was already playing that way before he even heard someone like Ornette Coleman. I do feel like Australia has created some quite unique and original sounding musicians who have a different way of, it's influenced by American jazz but — yeah.

MR: Do you think you could have made a living to your satisfaction if you had stayed in Sydney?

LP: I already was actually. I was a big fish in a small pond. I was doing Australian Anado Orchestra, I was doing a lot of very high profile projects. For me it was about learning. I wanted to — at the age of 25, it's sort of, 25 is when I left and it sort of, I look back on it now like I can't believe I moved to the other side of the world not knowing a single person, the only thing I had lined up was some lessons with Steve Coleman, that's who I had private lessons with. And then four years later I also got another grant from the Australian government and I actually studied with Lee Konitz. And that was on Steve's suggestion. So to study with the older masters before they go.

MR: In applying for the grant that made that possible I'm guessing you had to verbalize or write on paper what was your intent, what is it that you were so intent on learning?

LP: Well specifically I — well I didn't feel like I — I was working on some sort of much more complex concepts at the time in terms of different time signatures and different ways of — which is why I studied with Steve Coleman. Just I wanted to — I needed to hang out with some people in a different realm. And I feel like I had stopped learning actually. So I'm not sure what I wanted to learn. A big part of the picture is like in 1998 was my first exposure to the music of Ornette Coleman. And that changed me forever after that. His melodic and harmolodic concepts have influenced everything I've played and occurred ever since. That's been a big deal to me. So I also wanted to go with — more people were doing that sort of music as well.

MR: I've been reading, I wish I was more familiar with Ornette and his concepts but I've been reading about it. But much of it makes me scratch my head I must admit. And so I'm going to take the opportunity to ask you to sort of explain some of it.

LP: Well Ornette too, from what I've read, I did meet him a couple of times. I went to one of his birthday parties, that was amazing. That's from — I have a lot of stories — through a friend of mine Kenny Wessel, guitarist who played with him for quite a few years. But it seems like Ornette every time you asked him, "What is harmolodics?" he would answer a different way. And me and my friends in Sydney came up with a way of what we thought or what I thought harmolodics was. And for me it was just a very basic concept of the

been into the logic of melody, how if you — it's almost like if you do it, think of it in terms of a philosophy, if you have a statement here for the music to run its true course it has to go here and it has to go here and it has to go here. So following the natural logic of melody of one instrument and then layering that with another instrument like that makes up the harmony because there's no pre-set form. There are some recordings where Ornette did play over pre-set forms namely his very first album, where he plays very freely over the blues and stuff like that. But later ones they're not sticking to a form. You can tell what tune it is they're playing because it's also melody based. And that's where I'm coming from as well. It's all very much melody based. Even though I've also been very much into different types of rhythms as well, not just 4/4 swing.

MR: Was it a challenge to follow that thread with melodies and not be pulled into the standard okay I have four bars and eight bars and you're just naturally going there because of your life experience? Did you have to really consciously avoid that?

LP: No, no not really. And to me it was all about playing with other people and exploring I say this and therefore you say that so therefore I say this. It's just following natural logic. Now in fact I feel like when I play things without a form I actually sound more inside than when I play on set forms. Because I'm really using my ears and making music with another person like often, yeah, it sounds more inside than outside when I'm not using a set form. Does that make sense?

MR: It does. Karl Berger said something that just made me pause. He said playing free requires much more organization and thought. And like wow I'd never thought of that.

LP: And I completely agree with that. You know I completely agree with that. And playing a lot of that way made me so much more freer when I'm playing over form. And I would also add that doing a lot of different time signatures, like my favorite time signature is seven. And I don't know I just do games with myself. There was a time where I could pretty much sing or play every bebop head in seven. And I would learn tunes that I felt I needed to learn but I didn't really want to learn but I'd learn it in seven just to mess with myself. You know like "Moose the Mooche" [scats]. So that, doing that sort of stuff, you can imagine how that freed me up doing four/four. If I can be that comfortable in seven I didn't even, I wasn't even doing it to be able to feel freer in four/four, it just was me exploring being, and this was very much coming out of the lessons I had with Steve Coleman, getting my body feeling one thing, feeling different combinations of twos and threes, or where he never said numbers, it was longs and shorts. That's going back to African rhythms, Bulgarian rhythms, a long is three and a short is two so short-short-looong-short-short-loooong-short-short-loooong-short-short-looong. And when you look at like dances in Bulgaria there's a very old one that's three-two-two and it's funny we

not right. If you look at there's one that's — I now have gone off on a tangent, bear with me. There's a Bulgarian rhythm that's three-two-two that's — I don't know how many hundreds of years old it would be but it's [scats]. So you can see that you pause on one side and you pause on the other. And when I saw that dance I was performing it with a woman from Australia who studied in Bulgaria and I was on this tour performing for kids in the Outback. That was in in ninety — I don't know. And she was teaching them how to dance in seven and not saying that they were dancing in seven just like it's this [leans back and forth in chair]. And I just saw how oh my God it makes complete sense you know, that all of those, that music if we look back at the old dances like Greek music or Bulgarian music, if you look back at the dances that go with that they make complete — the music makes complete sense. When the dance went first and then the music went with the dance.

MR: Whoa that's very interesting. And I know I'm one of those people that always tries to make sense of things I hear, like gamelan music or — and I try to put it in a context that it doesn't belong. And then I get aggravated because I can't find one or something.

LP: Right. And then a lot of like West African music, they don't even have a concept of one. You know like they don't think in numbers. And that's — Steve Coleman was coming out of that concept. He used words like short and long. He didn't use numbers. And I think that was extremely good for me because even though he I don't know how can I explain this — the times we hung out together it wasn't really just a teacher-student. We were just doing stuff together. Sometimes we were transcribing Bird together and I'd be getting the melodic parts a lot quicker than him and he would get the very technical mathematical if you want to use — he would get those parts sort of quicker and so we were both learning from each other's strengths. So I've lost my train of thought though. Sorry.

MR: That's okay because I'm going to jump in with a quote about one of your tunes called "Gargoyle." Okay.

LP: Oh.

MR: It says, "Parrott borrows from a traditional 7/4 Bulgarian dance rhythm, 3-2-2, composing a five bar melody layered with West African style guitar melody in 5/8. There's a 14 bar phrase, and thus creates an unusual sense of balance. I couldn't have said it better.

LP: Yes. That quote, that's a quote of me explaining that tune. Yes.

MR: Okay well I suspected that when you started talking about all that.

LP: Yeah.

MR: It's very fascinating.

LP: And even though that's me explaining it, but I'm still coming, if you listen to it I seriously doubt you would hear it as music that fits together. You wouldn't be thinking about oh what time signature, you know what I mean? Like to me it always has to have an organic feel, has to feel natural, with no point I'm not doing it for it to sound technical, for it to sound like something. My favorite musicians play very hard stuff but you don't even realize it's very hard stuff. They make it so natural. That's what I aim for as well. So some of these things have come out of me practicing weird things, and then I'll try to make music out of it. That tune, to be honest, started a really, really, really long time ago and it didn't become a tune until a couple of years ago. The bass line was already there and this other 5/8 thing was already there. I never could figure out a melody though. I didn't know how to get it to work together. And I ended up just improvising along with it and coming up with an improvised melody that I just loved, over the top of it. But yeah, five bars of seven and seven bars of five and there is all that. I try to make it as natural as possible. I know that sounds crazy. You'd have to listen to the piece though.

MR: Well you're directing me to a vaguely formed question and also connected with I believe this is a quote from Ornette Coleman, "There is a music that has the quality to preserve life." And I wonder two things: what does music — what can music mean? And what do you hope an audience listening to your music will get out of it?

LP: First of all I'm tearing up because I relate so much to this, and especially since I've just come off the back of barely playing with anybody for almost a year and a half. And before I left on this trip, in May I finally played some duets at a little art gallery in Brooklyn with my friend Jamie Fox. And we're both vaccinated so we've both been getting together. He was the first person I didn't wear a mask around, we were both like can we do this? I think we can. And then we actually played a gig for about ten people in a loft gallery that opened up into the side of a street which was a great little Brooklyn gig, but I will never forget that feeling. I was very surprised by it, that it had been a very long time since I felt that much joy in playing. So it was a really wonderful feeling to realize, you know, you know in your head this means a lot to you, you've made a career out of this, but at the same time oh wow there are certain things you can't do if you're not playing for an audience. I mean there are certain things you just don't sort of play. You know rehearsing is not anything like performing. It really isn't. Because we went to places, musical places, that we hadn't been to and we just had massive smiles on our faces and it was so joyful. And I just want to really remember that feeling of how important it is, and the audience were feeling it too. That was very obvious as well. Everyone was just very very happy for the experience but also it was wonderful to have a dedicated listening audience. So that sort of feeling that I was trying to describe is what I

with the musicians that the audience cannot help but be brought into that and also taken along for that experience. And I would hope that, I suppose if my Dad can come to one of my gigs where I'm playing heavy harmolodics [gestures air quotes] — I'm saying that in embedded commas because like some of it, my, was it two years ago or maybe three years ago, but one of my last times I was out here playing gigs Harry, the bass player, came and he was not expecting to like my music. And he was fascinated. He was like, "I never listen to music like that but I love that. Why?" He was like, "Come over for wine and sourdough bread. And I'm fascinated, why did I like it?" And I said, "It's about melody" because I'm always coming from melody. So no matter how chaotic it might sort of sound if you just pick apart the pieces I always want to try to get a high form of, it's always coming from a loving, melodic place. I feel like melody is love, I really do. Yeah. So that's what I would hope an audience gets out of it. Like, love.

MR: I love that answer.

LP: And I'm tearing up because you know because of what's happened this year you know.

MR: Yeah. So you get to New York for lessons. Had you intended to go back at that point, to Australia?

LP: So I came in '93 for nine months and did study. I hadn't intended to come back at the end of nine months. I had visa issues, it's a long story I'm not going to go into, I was actually sort of forced out. That's a long story. We won't go there. And then I just saved up money, spent a year and a half in Australia and then came back permanently in '95. When I came back in '95 I knew, well New York and the vibe in New York, I felt at home. I didn't feel like a freak. Even though I had such great supportive musicians and I discovered myself musically in Australia, just culturally New York supported someone like me. I felt like, and I wondered because of my biggest hero being Bernie McGann I used to sound a lot like — I think I still have a lot of Bernie in me. I went to every one of his gigs for a whole year when I first moved to Sydney. He was playing about three times a week. It was fantastic. But always wondering if the way I play was only valid in Australia. That's what I didn't know, it was like I've gotten accolades for being an original voice in Australia. I didn't know if it would work anywhere else. So I remember going to like my first couple of jam sessions in the East Village, in '93, and a couple of people coming up to me and giving me advice. And I was sort of taken aback because I wasn't really getting that in Australia. And I realized it was coming from a place of, we like what you're doing, you need some advice. You know if someone just says, "Yeah you sound great." That means nothing to you. But if someone is saying hey have you ever checked out such-and-such and such-and-such? I reckon you could check that out. Or something like that, that's what it was like. And also I realized, and I got my first gigs

a month I asked him, "Why did you pick me? I hear all these — such great musicians everywhere, why did you pick me to be in your band?" He's like, "You don't sound like anybody else. And that was the penny dropping through the maze, like, ah, there's always room for another original voice in this music. And that's what's taken me, that's given me a career actually, because I don't sound like anyone else. And it doesn't mean that — I definitely have influences. You can hear some Ornette, you can hear Bernie McGann, on bari you can hear Gerry Mulligan. You can hear these influences but at the same time I feel like it was really great that when I was really young I made up my own way of doing things.

MR: This would be pure speculation, but if you grew up now, if you were starting now, where absolutely everything is available at the touch of a finger, I wonder if your playing would have turned out as original as it is?

LP: It's possible not, because what I am seeing from the times I've done some workshops like in Australia actually, and around the States, whenever I've gone to colleges or high schools or whatever and done workshops what I'm seeing is a lot of people shedding by themselves. And that is not cool. You've got to play with people. What — you know, practicing along with play-a-longs or just shedding by yourself you get used to not listening to somebody else. So for me, I always, I practice all the time with other people. Of course I do my own shedding but we spend a lot of time, you know, my friend Cameron Undy the bass player here, we would practice scales together to work on tuning. You know, and that would become tunes when we would mess around just improvising on a major scale or something. So young people, they've got to, I feel like there is a lot of — and I'm definitely generalizing here — a lot of people sounding the same, especially on saxophones. Younger people and I feel like it's possibly a product of what you're talking about, having access to everything and so I don't know you might get obsessed with one album like me and play it fifty times a day for three months you know.

MR: Which album was that?

LP: Well there were quite a few. Sometimes it was not me but the roommate who played "Blue Trane" every morning for three months. Like there was one note in Curtis Fuller's trombone solo that I still can't — uh — but early Ornette stuff, "Tales of Captain Black" which is another Ornette album, actually no, it's a co-led album with Jamaaladeen Tacuma, Roland Shannon Jackson, Ornette, and Bern Nix on guitar? No, I'm sorry, James Blood Ulmer on guitar. But also "Four and More," Miles. You know. It's just whatever we had access to, but we would play them to death. Definitely a lot of Eric Dolphy I'd have to say, "Far Cry!" I listened to that.

MR: How about Cannonball Adderley?

LP: Oh my God yes. Yeah, mainly through Miles, but I mean how can you touch like his rhythmic feel is just to die for. It's just — I love how free he is on the saxophone, it's just amazing, his time feel.

MR: Well every musician, I suspect especially in New York, has to wear a lot of musical hats to survive I would think. I think you're the first person I've spoken with in this manner that did significant copying, was a copyist.

LP: Yeah.

MR: And I think it's an interesting endeavor and I wondered if you started out with a quill — you know the special pens and the paper and then at some point did you transition to Finale or Sibelius?

LP: Yeah. I've learned so much. I have hundreds of composers' music on my computer. I've learnt so much from copying music it's not funny. I did start doing it [air quotes] professionally — well let me back up. Me and Nicki took exams every year, there's a system in Australia, part of the classical music system, Australian Music Examination Board, so you could take like classical piano, classical whatever exams, but you also, every year we would take musicianship exams and a theory exam. They were separate. So in other words like how to beautifully write music as a young kid, and they graded levels. So both me and Nicki took that. So we both have very good music handwriting. That's — and so those lessons have paid off for me big time because you know — so in the mid-90s I had a transcribing job of all of Booker Little's stuff for a publisher that he'd never ended up getting the rights for it but that was really wonderful, just — I transcribed all of that by ear from a cassette tape and wrote it all out by hand. I think it was '98 is when I started on computers and that was doing big band charts for somebody, and I would go to their place. I didn't have a computer, I didn't have to turn on a computer, I never had to re-boot computer, I didn't know anything about a computer but I could write a big band chart. So it was on Q-base and when I started sort of in 2002 I bought the program Sibelius. I was playing with Diva, Diva Jazz Orchestra. I joined them in — ooh when did I join Diva?

MR: 1998.

LP: Oh thank you.

MR: You're welcome.

LP: And they used to have a guy who was in his 90s still copying, hand copying. And there were a ton of mistakes so every rehearsal we would spend a lot of time correcting mistakes. And I had very quick ears, it would drive me insane that — hearing the mistakes and sometimes we'd have to keep going. I'm like, "But the second trombone has an F natural." You know. So I went up and said, hey, give me a shot, let me, you

know, copy one of Tommy Newsom's big band charts here, and I guarantee we will not have to correct any notes in the rehearsal. That's how it started.

MR: What did you get from Tommy Newsom? A hand-written —

LP: Hand-written big score, and I ended up doing a ton of stuff for Tommy. And he, I learnt the ethics of copying from Tommy. He told me some great stories. After the very first one I'm like, "So Tommy, I don't know whether to ask you, sometimes I know there's a missing flat but I know it's all in unison, do you want me to ask you about that or what's the ethics here? What should I do here? And in answer he said, "When Duke Ellington was trying out a new copyist he would put two mistakes in the chart and expect the copyist to correct them and not ask him about it." And Tommy said, "I want — you've got to make me look good." I was like, "Got it." And if it was something I really didn't, wasn't sure about of course I would ask him but that was the way we operated. And I just learnt so much from how to, especially how to arrange for saxophone section, like a 50s jazz arranging. So now I've really learned a lot from people like some of the arrangers from Freddie Cole, Tommy Newsom, then all the way through to say Butch Morris and I've even done stuff for Denardo Coleman, Ornette's son, to run the full gamut of all sorts of stuff of copying I've done.

MR: Did you ever get — well this would have maybe not been able to happen — a recording of the song in some form which would inform you about the arrangement and whether or not the arranger really — I can't finish my question. I'm just wondering you know if you heard a recording, perhaps a combo arrangement of something that then became a big band arrangement, might you have heard something in the combo that didn't seem to be jiving in the arrangement, and then have to bring that up with the arranger?

LP: Yes. A good copyist and, I feel like there's a lot less copyists around and I feel like the art of copying, I'm really glad to have had Tommy show me the ropes about certain things. Because a good copyist is also a proofreader, so you're not just writing everything out and then that's it. Like I think in the classical world that would be a different story, but in the jazz world you were expected to be a proofreader. So yeah, I did some stuff, some Ellington stuff for the New York City Ballet in 2018 and I was given some PDFs of them, so it was like Michelle Dorrance Dance, Michelle Dorrance tap dancing was doing stuff for the New York City Ballet and so it was orchestra plus big band. It was an amazing act. It was pretty amazing. So these — set to choreographed to these Duke Ellington pieces. So I was in charge of part transcribing, part orchestrating. Well actually transcribing and orchestrating, that sort of stuff. So I had to go sometimes to the recordings. I was given certain, you know, PDFs and things published and encountered mistakes. And so I wanted to be delicate about it.

MR: Well sure. You must get almost like a sense of ownership with these things, even if you're not the original composer. You're so invested in it.

LP: Oh well sure. I mean my name is at the bottom of everything I send out. And I'm very proud of the work I do. And I get, I do have a website but it's all been word of mouth. I seem to pretty much always have copying jobs around, I've got three on at the moment.

MR: Is there a musicians' union rate for this kind of work?

LP: Yes. I did do, there is. There is a contract, I don't even know the right terms. I've only worked under one union contract, although that New York City Ballet, I didn't realize until later that it should have been under a union contract. And that was for For Colored Girls, an off-Broadway production at The Public Theater. So that was all billed under the union contract because that's a union hall. So that was a big deal, and there was, I have to say it was very complex figuring out — it's by line and by page and by this and by that. It's very actually convoluted. It's — yeah.

MR: You get less bread for whole rests?

LP: Yeah, I don't even know. I'd have to get a lot of help from the union to figure out how to — they had to walk me through how that stuff works, that world works. It was an interesting look into that world though because very few Broadway copying houses are left. Oh my God they make an insane amount of money. It's actually one of the biggest expenses to getting a production up and running is the music, and all the music written down for people.

MR: I did not know that. So speaking of multiple hats, I know you've done some teaching with young children?

LP: Yep.

MR: And I wonder if you've found the need to invent things along the way that perhaps you didn't learn in the music conservatory when teaching young kids?

LP: Yeah, so I've never done as much teaching as I have over the last year, through the pandemic actually, because I was teaching for two different schools and both of these places have taught me a lot about teaching. One of them has just been like leading — three times a week just for an hour afternoon workshop sort of thing at a charter school in Brownsville, Brooklyn, so the poorest neighborhood in Brooklyn, the school is 98 percent black, but the program — everybody starts an instrument in seventh grade. In eighth grade everybody is in the band. It's fantastic. So it's like you know brass and saxophones and rhythm section instruments. And I'm what they call a Music Enrichment Teacher so I help with the beginners and I do like three months of boot camp saxophone and then in eighth grade they play it for the whole year. So that's what's been going on and I've been doing that for about six years or something. And also private lessons for

Poly Prep, which is again a middle school but out in Bay Ridge, Brooklyn. So it could not be more — it's a tale of two cities, what I teach at. Very interesting. They're just private lessons, but we put everything on Zoom for the kids in Brownsville. So at first I was doing video tutorials so I have come out of the pandemic with three new skills that I did not have before, one of them being I know music editing software now, I'm actually pretty good at Logic. I've put out some parody music videos as well as some more, like I did a six altos overlay thing with one of my tunes. Actually "Gargoyle" is up there. I did a all-baritone version of "Gargoyle." You can hear that, I'm playing shaker in five on that. That's up on YouTube, yes, that's where you should check it out. Yeah. And that's all baritones. So I came out that — and I started on iMovie and now I'm using Final Cut Pro. I've gotten very good at music editing, video editing, and sourdough bread. I've given away bread, I've made stencils, like I did a bass on top of one for Nicki and my friend Jamie who plays guitar gets a Les Paul guitar on top. But so at first — so I ended up doing a lot of group things on Zoom with kids as well as then the kids also were getting some private lessons over Zoom. And if I didn't have a ton of experience already teaching kids and being pretty good or being able to try to get kids up and playing pretty quickly but it didn't already have that, and being able to tell you things that go wrong with the saxophone, like a leaky pad and stuff like that. I've been very proud of like, "You know what? I think this pad might be leaking, can we try it —"

MR: I've done that, yes.

LP: Oh my God I'm definitely patting myself on the back for being able to troubleshoot stuff over Zoom. I do have a whisper room in our apartment in Brooklyn, which is a little soundproof, not quite soundproof but a booth like you used to see in a studio, it's a vocal booth, that I bought pre-pandemic because I had complaints from a neighbor in our apartment building. And so I got it three months before Covid hit. Then when Covid hit you could not buy one of those. Yeah. So my wife works for the New York City Health Department so she was working from home, she was activated to work on emergency response stuff. So she was working from home, I was working in that booth teaching kids. That's how we survived, that's how we survived the last year. It was obviously very intense at that place.

MR: Now I can see why that duo gig with ten people in the audience felt so good.

LP: Yes. Exactly. I've been playing in a booth for so long. And I have to say it's really good sound in there, I've actually dug it. It's — I've never had — I've always wanted one, to be honest. Because it's great, you go in there, you shut the door, and you practice. It's like going to an office instead of — you know, so I do like it and it is actually a good sound in there and I like that I'm not disturbing a ton of people. I can just go in there and

MR: Well we've been at this for a very enjoyable hour or so. I want to close with a non-musical question that I'm curious about. I wonder what people from other countries think about the United States on occasion, and because you've experienced two different countries, do you have anything that you could share with me about how the United States, how America has felt in the last number of years compared to how it felt when you first arrived?

LP: As I mentioned before, I am a dual citizen so I'm an Aussie-New Yorker or a Yank-a-roo, that's another word we use. I feel like it's so different. I've felt like, compared to when I first came, and I feel like this is a lot of people who come from outside of the U.S., especially as musicians, they come to New York and they just, they're living in New York in a New York bubble. They just want to be in New York. And the longer you stay here you have to deal with the fact that New York is in the United States. And all that comes with that. I actually have been to and performed in all fifty states, so I've done a lot of touring and obviously seen a lot of the country and because my accent has not gone anywhere at all I don't have to go very far before I'm not being understood, still and stuff like that. But in terms of then to now, and especially for the Trump years, I have a lot of Australian friends reaching out to me, "You guys okay? What the —" You know. Going forward I'm scared for the arts. I'm really scared for the arts. I feel we've already lost venues just locally and it's going to be a slow recovery I think, especially for improvised music and smaller venues. That is the future does scare me some. Because these are all, I'm talking about all the independent venues that, if they've managed to survive — it's just going to be hard. There's going to be less places to play, yeah.

MR: Okay. You have to keep inventing hats.

LP: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation. I'm very glad we did it and I didn't really ask you too much about the years you spent with the Diva Jazz Orchestra, which we had the group at Hamilton College a number of years ago.

LP: What year was — do you remember what year that was?

MR: It was probably four years ago.

LP: Ah so I'd already left. Yeah I left in 2015.

MR: Yeah. But speaking about reaching out to an audience, it was so inclusive and there was a whole crowd of junior high kids there and they came up on the stage afterwards and I was just watching this whole thing I said this is exactly what we need.

LP: Yes. There's another group I play with too that Ellen Rowe at the University of Michigan started in 2017 mainly because she's been teaching there for twenty years and there's still not enough young women going into improvised music at college and at the high school

hold but we are going to be doing some stuff in January. Great group. We did a recording in 2017 so Ellen, Marian, in Detroit, oh my God, I'm having a mental blank. Bass player from Detroit, oh my gosh. Oh that's terrible. Allison Miller on drums, the front line Ingrid Jensen, Virginia Mayhew, Tia Fuller and Melissa on trombone. Sorry. I haven't seen these people for a while, I'm forgetting everyone's last names.

MR: And you're fourteen hours away, it's okay.

LP: So, and I did experience that with Diva. It's like they need to see women up on stage, young men and women need to see mixed bands, all women bands, they need to see bands like this, that's what's going to create a really, a much more inclusive scene and music teaches people how to be good citizens a lot, that's what I believe as well. And you know I'm very proud of the outreach stuff that we did with Diva and also with this other group. Yeah.

MR: All right. Well thank you for your time.

LP: You're welcome. Thanks for asking these questions. You obviously did a lot of research which is very flattering. But thank you very much, I really enjoyed this.

MR: I wish you the best with your gigs down under. You know I was going to open — I'm so happy that I didn't do this, I was going to open up like singing "The Land Down Under" from Men at Work. I said, no that's too corny, don't do that.

LP: You are going to have to go onto YouTube though. I did do a Men at Work "Moo Can it Be Meow" Covid music video. I'm not kidding you.

MR: I have to see that.

LP: And Colin Hay, the lead singer did a cameo in it, that's a whole 'nother story for another time.

MR: Awesome. Well how many days do you have left before they allow you out?

LP: This is my eighth day, so I've got another six days, yeah.

MR: You're past the halfway point I guess.

LP: Yes I am.

MR: Well I hope we cross paths in the future in Brooklyn rather than in —

LP: Yes I agree, that would be great.

MR: Okay. Thanks, Lisa.

LP: Thanks.